

as the UFC itself attracts fans. "I think what's most important is that the sport becomes popular in the country. Once MMA becomes popular, the rest will fall into place. It also helps if the country has a history of martial arts. I don't know how much exposure MMA gets in India, but it's not enough! The exposure will grow, which will improve the training, which will lead to better fighters, and this, in turn, will cause the exposure to grow. So it will be a cycle of growth and improvement. When more kids become interested in MMA, there will be more gyms and more opportunities to train. India has a great wrestling culture, and I think that will transition to MMA quickly," he says.

Griffin is optimistic that India can follow the developmental path of nations like China, which had a negligible presence in the UFC not long ago but now boasts a UFC champion. "I think the country they most resemble in their growth will be China — another country with a large population, whose average personal wealth grew tremendously. They're also a country with a history and culture of martial arts," he adds.

Steady improvement

Even those aware of the challenges facing Indian MMA remain optimistic. "I'm actually very optimistic that we can improve the standard of coaching in the country. The best part of MMA is that you don't need to be the highest level in your individual sport. GSP (former UFC lightweight champion Georges St-Pierre) wasn't a top-level wrestler, boxer, or submission artist. But he was the greatest before the current era because MMA is about mixing these skills. That can be taught, rather than mastering a single skill set. One of the best MMA gyms in the world is City Kickboxing, in Auckland. Even though jiu-jitsu is crucial in MMA, neither of their founders had a background in it. They reached a high level through research and

constant improvement," Peeyush points out.

India's fighters are evolving too. "The amateur fighters I see in India now are better than the professional fighters when I started," admits Mainam.

New promotions are emerging, especially in the Northeast, says Lu. "There's a lot of untapped talent coming from the Northeast. Promotions in Arunachal (Arturo) and Assam (Bidang) are doing a lot of the right things. They're matching Indian fighters with the right opponents," he says.

More significantly, says coach Siddharth, the average age of India's fighters is getting younger. "If you look at the fighters currently at the international level, most are in their thirties or older (Anshul is 30, and

Puja is 31). Puja was a national-level wushu fighter for nearly 10 years before her first MMA opportunity. She and Anshul were pioneers who opened doors for others, but they got their chances later than some of the fighters we have now. (Current Road To UFC contender Mridul Saikia is 27). We also have promising fighters in their teens who've been preparing for a career in MMA for many years," he says.

If he ever feels discouraged, Siddharth recalls when he first started his MMA gym in Delhi two decades ago. "I left a career in finance in the UK to come back and start this. Back then, people thought I was crazy. 99 per cent of the first people who came to my gym were trying to lose weight. That's how MMA began in India. When I said I'd eventually produce a UFC fighter, my friends thought I was smoking something. But we got there. So when people criticise my fighters and say nasty things, I don't react. It's okay if they're talking about '19 seconds' now. Ten years ago, no one was even commenting. The fact that they're commenting means someone's in the UFC. We will get better, and there will be better things to talk about," he says.

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